

The Integral Principles of Interpersonal Conflict

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Abstract

Multicultural diversity and globalization have accelerated rates of interpersonal conflict within modern societies, outpacing the institutional capacity of nation-states to manage them effectively. This paper examines the integral principles of interpersonal conflict by synthesizing theoretical frameworks from conflict management, criminology, sociology, and political economy to produce a practical analytical model for conflict diagnosis and resolution. Interpersonal conflict is grounded in differing individual valuations of shared scarce resources. When argumentation — the primary mechanism of peaceful resolution — fails to balance self-advocacy with empathetic cooperation, conflict escalates predictably toward dysfunctional or destructive outcomes. Drawing on Whetten and Cameron's four sources of organizational conflict, this paper proposes a simplified categorical framework of Subjectivity, Objectivity, Greed, and Fear, mapped against five behavioral response archetypes: Forcing, Accommodating, Avoiding, Compromising, and Collaborating. Case studies from Italy, India, Nigeria, Germany, and the United States illustrate how ethnic and cultural heterogeneity simultaneously strains social cohesion and, when properly managed, yields competitive organizational advantages. The paper concludes that organizational conflict management theory serves as an effective microcosm for evaluating state-level conflict governance, and that the United States public justice system — constrained to reactive adjudication rather than proactive mitigation — is structurally limited in its capacity to produce consistently positive outcomes. Effective resolution at any scale depends on addressing conflicts in terms of issues rather than personal culpability.

Keywords: interpersonal conflict, conflict management, multiculturalism, social cohesion, argumentation, organizational behavior, peacemaking, public justice

Introduction

Multicultural diversity and inclusion, especially in dense population centers, has naturally increased rates of interpersonal conflict, polarized political incentives among government leadership, and incited economic class warfare among civilians. This should not come as a surprise to anyone that is familiar with human behavior; the problems which society faces today are the same problems humanity has always faced throughout recorded history. What is dire at the present time, however, is the fact that these problems are accelerating exponentially as first-world society grows and becomes more complex in its structure, evermore dependent on the steady advances of scientific research and technological development, while the antiquated, centralized institution of the nation-state struggles to stay relevant as the provider and protector of public welfare.

This was the premise in Couze Venn's contribution to *Negotiating Urban Conflicts* in his chapter "The City as Assemblage, Diasporic Cultures, Postmodern Spaces, and Biopolitics":

"Cities are already technological and social assemblages, operating in the form of coordinated networks of sub-systems relating to buildings, transport networks, commodity exchange, productive practices, apparatuses of training, regulation and communication, artistic practices, and so on. All these sub-systems are open systems, coherent in terms of their own rules and routines and flows, yet open to the effects of contiguous systems, that is to say, they are dynamic, complex, processual, and autopoietic in their operation. Change and turbulence in one part of the assemblage has effects for the other parts, often with indeterminate consequences" (Venn, 2006).

Fortunately, the advantage humanity now has over its ancestors is that conflict management has found its own niche of professional study, especially within the last century, coinciding with the rise of a globalized economy. The principles of interpersonal conflict are not a mystery, they have been clearly defined and theorized so the management thereof may be delegated in the most appropriate manner, thereby mitigating the risk of negative externalities in an already chaotic world. We learn of such an approach to conflict resolution in the practice of international peacemaking from Susan Allen in her experiential tome on the subject, *Interactive Peacemaking: A People-Centered Approach*, wherein she recounts her time involved in the peacemaking process between South Ossetians and Georgians after their most recent rise of tensions from the fall of the Soviet Union up to the violent war which took place in 2008. "The task of peacemakers," Allen writes, "is to resolve underlying issues that provoke conflict" (Allen, 2022).

Foundations of Interpersonal Conflict

The basics of interpersonal conflict are simple: differing individual valuations of collectively accessible scarce resources consequently yield conflicts of interest in the use of those resources as means to subjectively diverse ends. Whether they be natural (water, land, livestock), artificial (energy, technology), or even abstract (time, capital, strategy), when multiple individuals seek to control these resources, there will inevitably be differing opinions in how they are used to achieve a purpose. When conflicts of interest arise, argumentation ensues, and it is here where layers of intersecting cultural tradition, personal values, moral guidelines, codes of ethics, and the letter of authoritative law may establish a hierarchy of opinion leadership, thereby assigning rights to an individual or group of individuals which make them responsible for determining the best utilization of those resources. No matter how this hierarchy is structured, the result is that the rights to decide how scarce means are utilized unto subjective ends are shared only by those stakeholders who employ a leadership role among the group as a whole. All others, at some point, must follow suit, contend for that leadership role, or go their own way.

Argumentation seeks to resolve conflicts of interest through peaceful means, supported primarily by emotional intelligence in communications. For argumentation to succeed, participants must be willing to balance their need to satisfy their own opinions with an empathetic consideration for the position of the opposing party, if only agreeing to concede to

the decision of a third-party through arbitration. Without this collaborative environment, argumentation devolves quickly from questioning what is factually correct to who is morally right, and a whole new dimension in behavioral control may manifest at the volition of the incumbent leadership according to the worldview they most closely relate to. When argumentation fails outright, no amount of civilized discussion may quell the matter, and conflict easily escalates to the point of physical violence. It is, at that point, not a question of who is more logical in their observations or even who stands morally in the right, but who is faster, stronger, and more prepared to overpower others; the rest is history.

Multiculturalism: Global and Domestic Perspectives

A review of recent academic literature on the subject finds other global examples of teetering escalation and resolution of conflict which stems from multiculturalism: Migrant activism in Italy struggles against the backdrop of conflicting public policy due to a revitalized nationalist movement campaigning for government seats of power (Cappiali, 2022). In India, violent nationalist Hindus formed vigilante gangs of “cow protectors”, targeting Muslims with lynch mobs as the members of their movement gain government leadership roles and not only turn a blind eye to their crimes but endorse it through state policy (Nakamizo, 2021). In Nigeria, over 370 different ethnic groups of African origin inhibit the economic growth of the country as new generations of Nigerians struggle to escape both intra-and-inter-group conflicting claims to shared space and limited resources (Gure & Egbonu, 2022).

Among first-world societies, the United States of America has developed a multicultural globalized economy that taps into a talent pool of individuals from a myriad of social orders and experiences. The axiom ‘diversity is our strength’ has become a mantra for many in a post-civil rights society where the intermingling of race, gender, and cultural backgrounds has become the norm. How then can a society espouse the culture of diversity and inclusion as a strength when it simultaneously, and very obviously, originates exceedingly divisive and emotionally charged conflicts of interest among the populace? Conflicts which often incentivize escalation to the point of violence?

Hans-Hermann Hoppe reasonably demonstrated in his treatise, *Democracy the God that Failed*, that immigration, as far as the movement of people and property across state borders, becomes a forced integration with local property owners in regions with proportionally more public to private property legally permitted, incentivized by state welfare and the general provision of public goods (Hoppe, 2001). Understandably for private property owners, immigration as forced integration of foreign people, and by extension cultural values, presents numerous concerns when it comes to security and risk management, but the larger point to be made is that simultaneous to implementing incentives for forced integration of foreign peoples, the state then grants itself monopolistic powers to tax private property owners for the public provision of security of property and persons from the same unknown variables migrants present.

The idea of immigration and violent crime rates being positively correlated is a heavy subject that has received much attention from sociologists and criminologists alike, but of recent analytical studies of empirical evidence, two books stand out from the rest: First,

Immigration and Crime: The Effects of Immigration on Criminal Behavior seeks to update criminological understanding of what's typically referred to as the 'social disorganization theory', in that theoretically immigration introduces entropic variables to an otherwise homogeneous neighborhood which disorganizes its social cohesion. An in-depth description of the methodology and approach to these analyses is given for more technical readers, but plainly summarized for the layman: immigration has no direct effect on crime, but it does share a strong correlation indirectly through the dimensions of poverty, heterogeneity, and residential instability, all strong empirical factors on violent crime rates (Stowell, 2007).

This is later affirmed in the study outlined in *Ethnic Diversity and Social Cohesion*, which explores the dimension of interpersonal trust in the context of ethnic diversity and social cohesion. It endeavors to discover if concern is warranted when analyzing the growing ethnic diversity in Europe, particularly in Germany, and its effects on the provision of public goods by the state. The author conducts an extensive review of contemporary empirical research on the subject and concludes that what is necessary to make sense of it begins with understanding mediating mechanisms, such as subjective perceptions of diversity (heterogeneity), and moderating conditions, such as socio-economic deprivation (poverty). With these concepts taken into factor, the author finds that there is evidence that ethnic diversity challenges social cohesion in Germany in terms of interpersonal distrust, no matter if the subjective was a native, recent migrant, or next-generational migrant. However, in further analyzing social cohesion, Schaeffer finds that while interpersonal distrust occurs cognitively on ethnically diverse lines, social integration begins when the locals of the community are forced to work together to see improvement in the structural dimension of social cohesion. This study is a valuable insight into how ethnically diverse communities are forced to cooperate when the problems which they face as a group require the development of interpersonal trust outside their in-group (Schaeffer, 2014).

Conflict Management in Organizations

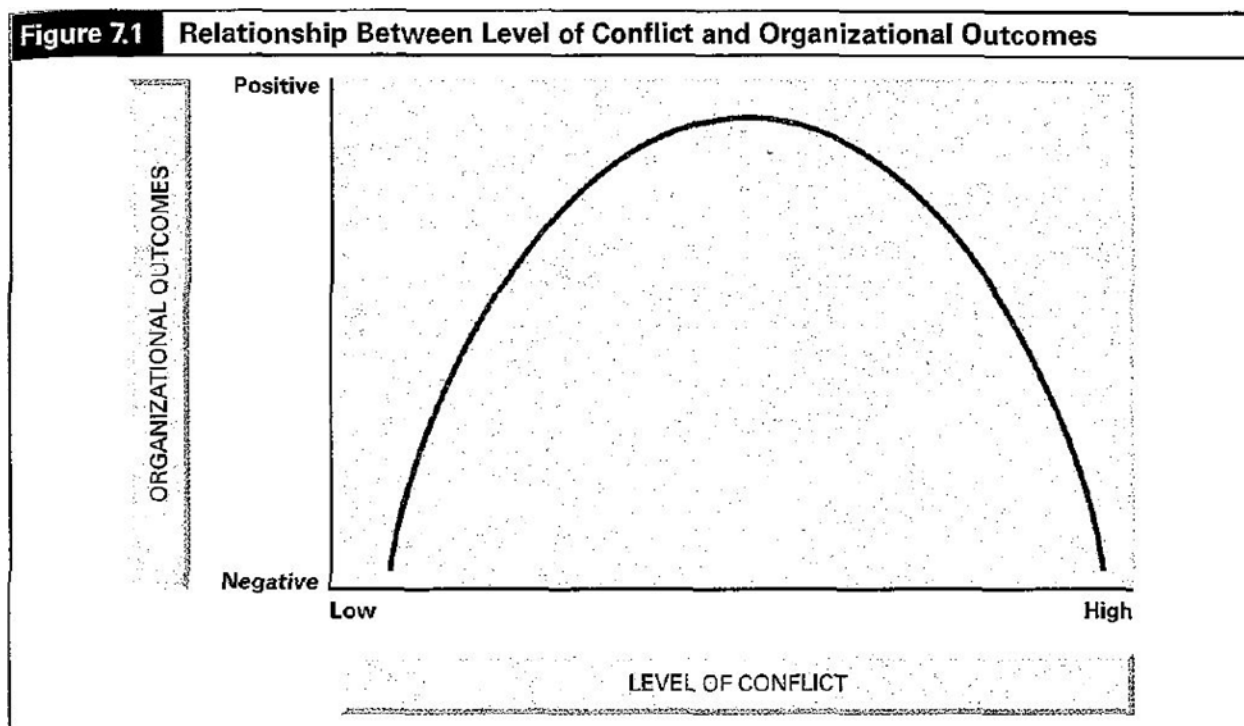
The fact of the matter is that diversity is a double-edged blade, demonstrated in leading management science developed and implemented in the corporate world of business. Even though increased diversity in a group introduces more conflicting subjective values and reduces individual confidence and trust of others, organizations which lack a degree of diversity become uncompetitive in their markets as leadership becomes homogeneous. Diversifying the talent pool in which leadership is recruited from allows an organization to adopt a variety of 'lenses' which lend to that organization's worldview, fundamentally aiding its overall ability to identify opportunities to out-perform others in the global marketplace. Leadership is incentivized to promote a diverse corporate culture to further their business interests while betting on their ability to effectively manage conflict as it arises, exhorting their constituents to be inclusive in their day-to-day interactions.

In Chapter 7 of the text *Developing Management Skills*, authors Whetten and Cameron outline conflict management strategies understanding that organizational conflict is not only a given, but a necessity: "*Interpersonal conflict is an essential, ubiquitous part of organizational life. In fact, given the current business trends toward workforce diversity, globalization, and*

joint ventures, how managers from different organizations and cultures deal with conflict is an increasingly important predictor of organizational success... Conflict is the lifeblood of vibrant, progressive, stimulating organizations. It sparks creativity, stimulates innovation, and encourages personal improvement” (Whetten & Cameron, 2006).

However, it is admitted that mismanaged interpersonal conflict creates detrimental results, and in some instances, conflict cannot be productively managed at all: *“Some people have a very low tolerance for disagreement. Whether this is the result of family background, cultural values, or personality characteristics, interpersonal conflict saps their energy and demoralizes their spirit. Also, some types of conflicts, regardless of frequency, generally produce dysfunctional outcomes. These include personality conflicts and arguments over things that cannot be changed... Conflicts stemming from incompatible personal values and needs are some of the most difficult to resolve. They often become highly emotional and take on moral overtones” (Ibid.).* To manage conflict effectively, then, leadership must be comfortable with different kinds of conflict and respond to conflicting parties appropriately, even if it means simply separating them for a time to ‘cool off’.

The graphic used to illustrate the need to effectively balance and manage conflict shows that when conflict is improperly managed to escalation, the outcome for the organization is virtually the same as if there were no conflict at all.



1- From Page 381 of *Developing Management Skills 7th Edition* (2006)

Sources of Interpersonal Conflict

According to Whetten and Cameron, there are four primary sources of interpersonal conflict:

1. Personal differences in perceptions and expectations,

2. Informational deficiencies which misrepresent circumstances,
3. Role incompatibility where individual goals and responsibilities are misaligned, and
4. Environmental stress stemming from resource scarcity and uncertainty.

Interpreted here, often the most common first source is derived of conflicting individual points-of-view and values where differing lenses of subjective points-of-view give rise to diverse individual motives. These motives are developed into actions based on the individual's understanding of their environment and their priorities to act on that understanding. The second source stems from the lack of consensus concerning contextual data, usually in the form of objective empiricism. This data is either of poor quality or otherwise unreliable, prompting inefficient and/or ineffective action by subjective participants whose personal values are informed by this data. Because humans are subjective beings observing and acting upon an external environment, the diametric on which these first two sources lie implies they are integrally intertwined. This *subjective/objective* experience thus creates a feedback loop which exacerbates conflict both within *subjective* points-of-view and without onto an *objective* worldview. As individuals with similar internal/external feedback loops come together, they harmonize and create group cohesion in their shared *objective* worldview while individuals with dissonant feedback loops tend to separate from one another, adhering to their own *subjective* points-of-view.

The third source denotes conflicting incentives among parties, meaning the ensuing contest will produce one of three results dependent on the quality of argumentation and the ending position of those parties: *win-win*, *win-loss*, or *lose-lose*. The fourth source refers to environmental factors especially outside the control of conflicting parties. Conflicts from these last two sources, derived of internal and external variables respectively, both affect the timing and motivation for the initiation of action. This is more simply understood as the concept of time preference, where *greed* is associated with the shorter-term while *fear* is associated with the longer. As conflicting points of view develop, the time-preference of each subjective participant often determines whether argumentation can constructively occur or not, as individuals with an extreme short-term preference (abstractly defined in terms of timing and motivation as Impatience/Attraction) are generally incompatible with those capable of extreme long-term preference (Patience/Aversion).

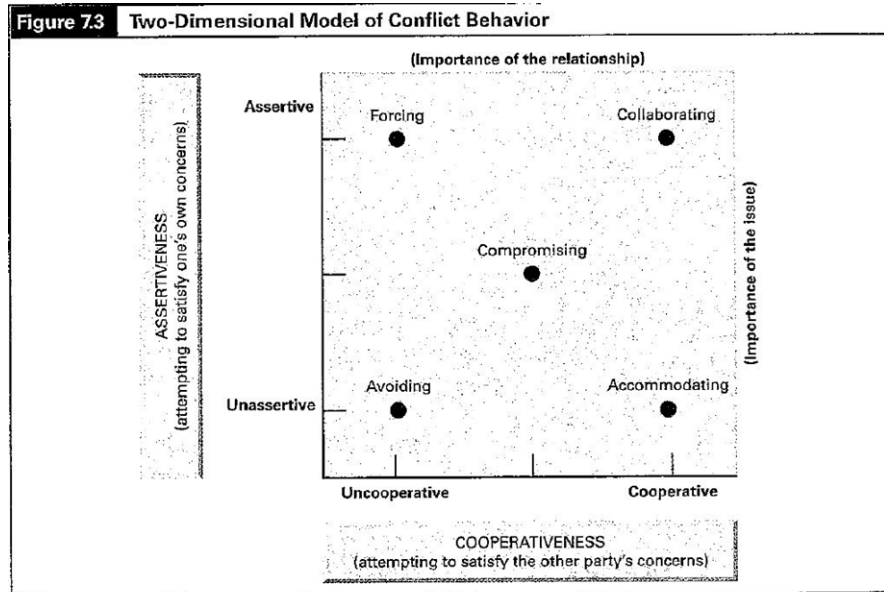
For purposes here, these four categorical sources are referred to as conflicts of 1: Subjectivity (Internal), 2: Objectivity (External), 3: Greed (Force), and 4: Fear (Avoidance). While it is possible for conflicts to display more than one symptom of these categories, the goal is to correctly identify the origin and trigger of conflict among the symptoms observed using these four categories as guidance.

Behavioral Responses to Conflict

When argumentation takes place, each participant expresses a degree of both *Assertiveness* and *Cooperativeness*, the latter as a degree of empathetic consideration for the opposing party, the former with the advocating of self-interests. Understanding these personality dynamics when individuals react to confrontation allows conflict managers to approach a resolution more

effectively. Conflicts may be expressed on a two-dimensional binary model established on an axis of *Assertiveness* (considering importance of relationship) and *Cooperativeness* (considering importance of issue), illustrating five categories of possible responses to confrontation regardless of their source:

1. Forcing: *Assertive-Uncooperative*
2. Accommodating: *Unassertive-Cooperative*
3. Avoiding: *Unassertive-Uncooperative*
4. Compromising: *Neutral*
5. Collaborating: *Assertive-Cooperative*



2 - From Page 387 of *Developing Management Skills 7th Edition* (2006)

Analysis and Application

When analyzing conflict, one must first identify the relationship of opposing parties, categorizing the *subjectivity* of the conflict in terms of *Cooperativeness*, or willingness to debate the issues. Next, determine what external factors have informed the positions of each party, categorizing the *objectivity* of the conflict in terms of *Assertiveness*, or how aggressive each party will defend what they believe to be *objective* truth. Lastly, identify the dimensions of *greed* and *fear* which ultimately affect the importance of the issues versus the importance of relationship of opposing parties. If argumentation can only occur when a degree of *cooperation* among parties exists, then understanding what obstacles prevents *cooperation* is the first step to effectively manage conflict for a positive, functional, or otherwise constructive outcome. Because conflict is inherently culturally founded, the *subjective* importance of relationship among conflicting parties versus the *objective* importance of the issue at hand cannot be underscored further: this is the most effective measuring tool conflict managers have at their disposal when it comes to resolving conflict, analyzing the sources of conflict, and strategizing contingencies for future management. From here, conflict managers can quickly determine if argumentation is needed, feasible, and at what degree of risk there is of the conflict in question escalating to a negative, dysfunctional, or otherwise destructive outcome.

For purposes here, conflict management theory at the organizational level will be viewed as a microcosm of multicultural society at large. With an understanding of corporate conflict management theory, the public justice system of the United States of America can now

be assessed in these same terms of positive and negative outcomes. Of course, there are some stark differences between how a firm manages interpersonal conflict compared to how the state manages conflict among its constituents. One major difference is that an organization has the opportunity to thoroughly vet their employees prior to including them in their corporate social structure, where the state really does no such vetting unless individuals are from outside the legal structure of the state. From this standpoint, it is easy to see that not only is the state at a disadvantage when it comes to managing conflict, but there is also really no way for the state to preemptively act to mitigate interpersonal conflict on such a grand scale, at least not without relying on questionable systems of surveillance and feedback (which is a whole other topic in of itself.) The goal for the state, then, is not necessarily to mitigate conflict but to create a one-size-fits-all blanket of contingencies for *uncooperative* persons and enact consequences upon them on a case-by-case basis.

Conclusion

Ultimately, the pivot point which determines whether conflict resolution efforts results in a positive or negative outcome rests solely on whether that conflict can be addressed in terms pertaining to *issues* of values and needs versus *ad hominem* accusations of personal wrongdoing. For leadership to effectively address and resolve interpersonal conflict, then, they must do so in terms of troublesome issues, not troublesome people, otherwise it can be almost assured that conflict will escalate beyond repair. From here it is possible for the US public justice system to be accurately reviewed, its major players analyzed, and to determine whether or not the state is sufficiently managing interpersonal conflict among citizens, producing overall positive outcomes which are cognizant of the long-term consequences for multicultural society.

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